

THE CRAFT OF CGI

The first frame is the decision

They review the whole film. It was lost before they started watching.

THOMAS HOWCROFT

THE PROBLEM

Most briefs never mention it

A brief specifies the product, deliverables, deadline. It does not say what the viewer should feel in the first frame. That gap is where most product films are lost.

WHY IT MATTERS

The opening is not a given

Default: standard camera move, product centred, neutral grade. The opening is treated as a starting point, not a decision. It is the most important creative decision in the film.

THE WINDOW

Three seconds buys nothing

The viewer decides whether to care before anything moves. Not at the product reveal. Not at the grade. At the first frame. Earning it requires an intentional choice.

WHAT TO DO

The brief must specify the feeling

Not the camera angle. Not the colour grade.
The feeling the first frame has to produce.
Most briefs leave it blank. Most reviews skip past it entirely.

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If your brief does not specify what the viewer should feel in the first three seconds, it is not finished yet.

What does your opening frame tell your viewer to do?